CHAPTER 51

COVID

8 December 2021–18 January 2022

AUSTRALIA vs ENGLAND, five Test matches

Australia won the series 4-0

We're flying out to Australia in a week. I'm dreading this Ashes. I don't know anyone who isn't. Covid protocol is extremely tight still and the world is still in and out of lockdown. We've been given information about what the tour will be like – that there will be severe restrictions compared to what we're used to. It's my mum's 60th and we're at an Airbnb in the Lake District. If the family stay as a bubble and don't go out anywhere, we think, it should be fine. We get tested at home. They come to our house, masked and gloved, and one by one move through the family, poking the swab as far as it will go up each nostril. We are all clear, they tell us.

In the Lake District, we go and meet my mum and dad, sister and brother-in-law too. We are having a lovely evening, watching *Strictly*, doing the most ordinary things that have now become rare and sacred. The tour will be so isolated, so lonely, so horrible, that I am just taking it in while I can, a level of neutrality and ease. It is imminent too as I'm leaving in a week. The next day, as we are walking, I get a phone call: Lola has tested positive for Covid. I'm suddenly struck cold. I shouldn't be here. In a panic, no physical contact, a flash of rushed goodbyes, we are packing up. 'We shouldn't really be here,' I am suddenly saying to them. 'We have to go.' We drive home together, the windows wide open, everyone facing forward in masks, as if a nuclear disaster is upon us.